



Experts' Opinions

Former policemen's views on improving megacity surveillance

D.S. SOMAN



Former DGP,
Maharashtra

■ A special force should be set up on the lines of the NSG.

■ Revive the dismantled Crime and Special branches of the police.

ARVIND INAMDAR



Former DGP,
Maharashtra

■ A federal agency to offer intelligence to key states is the need of the hour.

■ Allow specialised forces like the ATS to investigate in a free and fair manner.

V. RANGANATHAN



Ex-Chief Secretary
Maharashtra

■ Political interference in postings and transfers should be stopped.

■ The absence of a well-equipped strike force has crippled the civil police.

spots in a city is needed on a priority basis. Most of these spots need to be put under CCTV surveillance. A clear and frequent chain of communication needs to be established between the police and local security agencies involved in protecting other high-density targets.

More important than the application of technology is the beefing up basic policing. This involves reviving the informer network that had once given Mumbai's police its reputation. Revitalising *mohalla* committees in Mumbai (which were undermined by a former joint commissioner of police) and making Delhi *rwaa* more proac-

tive in their own security can fill in the remaining gaps.

A global survey of 25 megacities released in 2007 revealed that 59 per cent respondents chose public surveillance over protection of privacy. Indians would probably agree with the majority view, even if it means pushing for the institution of a national identity card.

There is another radical solution that may only exacerbate the already-frosty relations between state home departments and police force but certainly fulfill the premise of this argument: that a specific threat needs a specific and specialised response. Former Maharashtra

DGP D.S. Soman suggests drawing home secretaries from IPS rather than the IAS, given their experiences in the arena of armed conflict.

These are all common sense measures and can only work if strict timelines are applied for implementation: as late as November 2008, senior home ministry officials were asked about the fast-tracking of a 2005-06 megacity policing scheme. Just over three weeks later, 10 terrorists held India's most mega of cities in a death grip for 60 hours. All reasons, legitimate or otherwise, for further delays in securing our megacities have just evaporated.